

HIDDEN GEMS

A YouTube Discovery Platform Initiative

BRD

Hidden Gems — Niche Creator Discovery Platform

Business Requirements Document

Project	Hidden Gems Discovery Layer (YouTube)
Document Version	1.0
Status	Draft for Stakeholder Review
Date	July 14, 2026
Prepared By	Product Management / Business Analysis
Classification	Internal — Product & Engineering Confidential

Document Control

Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Description of Change
0.1	2026-06-20	Business Analyst	Initial draft from discovery workshops
0.5	2026-06-30	Product Manager	Incorporated research findings & personas
1.0	2026-07-14	Business Analyst	Baselined for stakeholder sign-off

Approval Sign-Off

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Executive Sponsor / VP Product			
Director, Creator Ecosystem			
Director, Discovery & Recommendations			
Legal & Trust and Safety Lead			
Finance / Monetization Lead			

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1. Executive Summary

YouTube's recommendation ecosystem systematically over-indexes on established, high-subscriber creators, leaving mid-tier and niche creators (1,000–500,000 subscribers) structurally unable to reach viewers who are actively seeking their content. Independent secondary research and primary interviews with 30 heavy viewers confirm this bias, and competing platforms (TikTok, Instagram, Twitch, LinkedIn) are actively investing in discoverability features to close the gap.

This Business Requirements Document defines the business case, scope, and requirements for Hidden Gems — a dedicated discovery surface inside YouTube that matches niche, mid-engagement content to high-intent viewers using creator-authored, AI-verified content labels combined with behavioral ranking. Hidden Gems introduces a creator-facing labeling workflow, a viewer-facing discovery surface (home feed, search, watch page, and creator profile touch-points), and an attribution layer that measures incremental traffic and revenue delivered to featured creators.

The initiative is sponsored by Product Management on behalf of the Creator Ecosystem and Discovery & Recommendations organizations, and is scoped for a phased rollout beginning with a closed creator beta and culminating in a platform-wide, advertiser-extensible discovery layer.

Business Outcome: The single measurable outcome this initiative is accountable for is the number of incremental daily profile visits gained by creators featured in Hidden Gems (the North Star Metric).

2. Business Context and Problem Statement

2.1 Market Context

YouTube operates within a creator economy valued at approximately \$250B and growing at roughly 21% CAGR (2023–2024), hosting an estimated 63.8M creators and 2.5B monthly active users. Despite this scale, only a fraction of the platform's 207M creators worldwide reach audiences that are genuinely interested in their content, and every major competing platform is actively investing in creator discoverability.

2.2 Problem Statement

Analysis of the current state surfaced a consistent two-sided problem, validated through primary research and root-cause ("five whys") analysis:

Viewer-side problem

- Viewers cannot discover new creators within their niche of interest.
- Root cause: viewers are bombarded with mainstream content because there is no personalized surface built around stated or inferred preference.

Creator-side problem

- Mid-tier creators cannot reach their target audience.
- Root cause: target viewers never see these creators in their feed, because algorithmic ranking favors mainstream, already-popular media.

2.3 Quantified Business Impact

Impact Area	Metric	Source / Basis
Creator burnout	80% of surveyed creators report burnout	Primary creator research
Viewer session abandonment	50% of viewers abandon sessions without finding content	Primary viewer research
Pressure to chase trends	39% of creators feel pressured to chase trends over authentic content	Primary creator research
Perceived algorithm bias	78% of viewers feel the algorithm favors already-popular creators	Survey of 30 heavy viewers
Inability to discover niche creators	75% of viewers cannot find niche creators they want	Survey of 30 heavy viewers
Discovery satisfaction	3.1 / 5 average rating of current discovery tools	Survey of 30 heavy viewers

2.4 Stakeholder Impact Map

No single stakeholder is well-served by the current discovery model:

Stakeholder	Current-State Pain
Viewers	Overloaded with similar, mainstream content; cannot locate niche creators matching real interests.
Creators (mid-tier)	Face intense competition for visibility, leading to burnout and stalled channel growth.
YouTube (platform)	Faces monetization pressure and retention risk as competitors solve discoverability faster.
Advertisers	Experience low ROI on undifferentiated inventory concentrated around mainstream content.
Regulators	Increasing scrutiny of content-quality and algorithmic fairness practices.

3. Business Objectives and Success Criteria

The following objectives are derived directly from the problem statement and are the basis against which all requirements in Section 6 are traced.

ID	Objective	Success Criteria
BO-01	Increase discoverability of niche/mid-tier creators	Measurable increase in incremental daily profile visits attributable to Hidden Gems (North Star Metric)
BO-02	Improve viewer discovery satisfaction	Discovery satisfaction score improves from current 3.1/5 baseline
BO-03	Increase viewer engagement & retention	Growth in click-through rate, profile visits, subscribes, and returning-viewer rate on the Hidden Gems surface
BO-04	Grow incremental creator revenue	Measurable ad, membership, and Super Chat revenue attributable to Hidden Gems traffic
BO-05	Defend competitive position on discoverability	Feature parity or advantage vs. TikTok, Instagram, Twitch, and LinkedIn discovery mechanisms
BO-06	Maintain trust, safety & quality of labeling ecosystem	AI label precision $\geq 90\%$; abuse/spam rate held below defined threshold

4. Scope

4.1 In Scope

- Creator-facing labeling workflow integrated into the upload/publish flow in YouTube Studio.
- AI-based label verification and taxonomy matching to prevent spam and abuse.
- Viewer-facing Hidden Gems discovery surface on the YouTube home tab, including niche preference chips.
- Search-by-intent capability allowing viewers to search directly by niche label.
- Hidden Gems surfacing on the video watch page (related content) and creator profile page.
- Behavioral ranking/recommendation logic that matches labeled content to viewer preference and history.
- Attribution and analytics layer measuring incremental visits and revenue delivered to featured creators.
- Phased go-to-market covering closed creator beta, limited viewer rollout, global scale, and an advertiser/ecosystem extension.

4.2 Out of Scope (Phase 1)

- Changes to the core, mainstream home-feed ranking algorithm outside the Hidden Gems surface.
- Monetization products beyond existing ads, memberships, and Super Chats (e.g., new commerce formats).
- Advertiser self-serve buying against Hidden Gems labels (deferred to Phase 4 — Ecosystem Play).
- Non-video formats (Shorts integration is explicitly deferred to Phase 3).
- Third-party/platform-external distribution of Hidden Gems content.

4.3 Target Users / Market Segments

Segment	Description
Mid-tier creators	Creators with 1,000–500,000 subscribers producing consistent, quality niche content but lacking proportional reach.
High-intent viewers	Viewers averaging 1+ hour/day on YouTube who actively seek niche content but are underserved by mainstream recommendations.

5. Assumptions, Constraints, and Dependencies

5.1 Assumptions

- Creators are willing to invest time labeling content if reach improvement is demonstrable (research indicates labeling can improve reach by approximately 3x).
- Sufficient labeled supply can be established during the closed beta before opening the viewer-facing surface.
- Existing YouTube ranking infrastructure can be extended to incorporate label affinity signals without a full platform re-architecture.
- Viewer preference and watch-history data already collected under current privacy policies is sufficient to power initial ranking.

5.2 Constraints

- Solution must operate within existing YouTube content policy, privacy, and regional compliance frameworks.
- AI label verification must meet a minimum 90% precision threshold before any viewer-facing rollout beyond beta.
- Platform performance guardrails: 99% uptime at peak and p95 latency under 400ms for any new surface.
- Budget and engineering capacity are allocated in phases; Phase 2+ funding is contingent on Phase 1 beta success criteria.

5.3 Dependencies

Dependency	Description
Trust & Safety	AI label verification model and abuse-review workflows must be production-ready ahead of creator beta.
Recommendations Platform	Core ranking infrastructure team must expose hooks for label-affinity signals.
YouTube Studio	Upload/publish flow must be extended to surface labeling UI without disrupting existing publish SLAs.
Analytics & Attribution	Existing creator analytics pipeline must support new incremental-visit and revenue-attribution metrics.
Legal / Policy	Review and sign-off on label taxonomy, regional content rules, and advertiser extension (Phase 4).

6. Business Requirements

Each business requirement (BR) is traceable to one or more business objectives (Section 3) and is further decomposed into functional/technical requirements in the companion Functional & Technical Requirements Document (FTRD).

BR ID	Requirement	Priority	Traced Objective
BR-01	The business shall provide creators a mechanism to attach niche descriptor labels to videos at time of upload or publish.	Must	BO-01, BO-06
BR-02	The business shall verify all creator-submitted labels using an automated process before labels become viewer-facing.	Must	BO-06
BR-03	The business shall present a dedicated discovery surface on the YouTube home tab that shows niche/mid-tier creator content matched to viewer preference.	Must	BO-01, BO-03
BR-04	The business shall enable viewers to search directly by niche/intent label and be routed to matching niche creator content.	Must	BO-01, BO-03
BR-05	The business shall surface “Featured in Hidden Gems” content and related recommendations on the video watch page.	Should	BO-01, BO-03
BR-06	The business shall provide a direct discovery path from Hidden Gems content to the originating creator's profile page.	Must	BO-01, BO-04
BR-07	The business shall measure and report incremental profile visits and revenue attributable to Hidden Gems for each featured creator.	Must	BO-01, BO-04
BR-08	The business shall roll out Hidden Gems in phased stages, beginning with a closed creator beta prior to general viewer availability.	Must	BO-05, BO-06
BR-09	The business shall provide creators visibility into their Hidden Gems performance (views, CTR, revenue) via an analytics dashboard.	Should	BO-04
BR-10	The business shall maintain non-functional guardrails (uptime, latency, label precision, recommendation relevance) throughout rollout.	Must	BO-06
BR-11	The business should extend the labeling taxonomy to advertisers for contextual buying in a future phase, without compromising organic discovery quality.	Could	BO-04, BO-05

Priority key: Must = MoSCoW “Must have” (launch blocking); Should = high value, targeted for launch where feasible; Could = desirable, may be deferred without blocking launch.

7. Success Metrics and KPIs

North Star Metric: Number of incremental daily visits gained by creators featured in Hidden Gems.

Tier	Metric	Definition
L1	Viewer engagement on Hidden Gems	Video CTR, profile visits, and subscribes per day originating from the surface
L1	Revenue via Hidden Gems content	Ad, membership, and Super Chat revenue attributable to the surface
L2	Clicks on Hidden Gems per day	Feature visibility and entry rate
L2	Returning viewers to Hidden Gems	Stickiness — whether viewers return to the surface

7.1 Non-Functional Guardrails

Guardrail	Target	Rationale
Uptime during peak	99%	Discovery surface must be reliably available during highest-traffic periods
p95 latency	< 400ms	Discovery must not degrade overall app responsiveness
AI label precision	90%	Protects viewer trust and prevents label spam/abuse
Recommendation relevance	85%	Ensures matched content is genuinely relevant to stated/inferred viewer preference

8. Business Risks

Risk	Potential Impact	Mitigation
Poor viewer adoption of the new surface	North Star Metric fails to move; investment does not pay back	In-product marketing plus rolling viewer surveys to iterate the surface quickly
Regional irrelevance of surfaced content	Poor experience in specific markets; uneven adoption	Demographic-based content surfacing with feedback-driven rotation
Algorithm fails to reliably surface niche creators	Objective BO-01 unmet; creator trust erodes	Continuous A/B testing and real-time behavioral audits
Label spam / abuse by bad actors	Viewer trust erosion; guardrail breach	AI verification with 90% precision target plus human review escalation path
Creator supply insufficient at viewer launch	Thin content pool undermines discovery quality	Closed beta explicitly sequenced before viewer rollout to build supply first

9. Business Rollout Plan

Delivery is sequenced in four business phases; detailed functional scope per phase is defined in the FTRD and Process Map documents.

Phase	Milestone	Business Description
1	Closed creator beta	Invite 5,000 mid-tier creators across 3 niches; ship labeling flow and gather label taxonomy in the wild.
2	Viewer surface rollout	Enable Hidden Gems on home for 5% of eligible viewers; A/B test entry point, ranking, and card design.
3	Scale and retention loops	Global rollout with creator revenue reporting, personalized notifications, and Shorts integration.
4	Ecosystem play	Open labels to advertisers for contextual buying; position Hidden Gems as the platform's discovery layer.

10. References

- Functional & Technical Requirements Document (FTRD) — Hidden Gems, v1.0
- User Stories Backlog — Hidden Gems, v1.0
- Process Maps — Hidden Gems, v1.0
- Use Case Specifications — Hidden Gems, v1.0
- Supporting Artifacts (Glossary, RACI, RTM, Risk Register, Data Dictionary) — Hidden Gems, v1.0
- Source: Hidden Gems Product Case Study deck (research synthesis, personas, and GTM plan)